

[CanExport 2025 Prep Video Link](#)

Feb 7th 2025

Make sure you are recording and screen sharing on Zoom/ RingCentral.
Be conscious of your time.

PART A: BUDGET DOC - 20 - 30 mins

This is where you will share your screen and go through the budget to discuss each activity.

This helps because if there are missing pieces, it's addressed while the client is there, so that our writers can hear their response and write accordingly.

This is the most important part of the call as the application writeup about project activities should have the most details/justification.

You don't have to ask all of the questions as you may have some of these answers already.

*Some clients are really on top of their budget and how it's broken down, while others don't care, so it's helpful to discuss the following for **each activity**:*

- Confirm each market (country/region) and then ask the client what specific states or cities they are targeting in each market
- Confirm project start date - ensure that it is at least **60 business days** from the estimated submission date
- Confirm project end date - make sure that it is realistic for the client to spend all of the money in their project budget by this date.
- Discuss the main purpose of **each** activity
 - Ask how each activity relates to the overall entrance strategy for the project. How it will help the applicant reach their goals in the target market.
- Confirm the start and end date of **each** activity
- Confirm the total cost of **each** activity. Ensure that there are no monthly retainers and costs are in CAD.
 - **Flag any advisory expenses over \$10K. A statement of work, that specifically indicates the target markets, must be obtained from advisors for these activities.**
- Discuss the vendors for **each** activity.
 - Why did they hire them or choose to work with them?
 - Have they worked with them before? If it is a consultant or freelancer, have they ever been internally employed by the applicant company?
 - Add in their URL to their company website or LinkedIn Page as we will need to write about the consultants organization and their mandate
 - *Emphasize that the program does a thorough audit to ensure Arm's Length for service partners. No board members, existing advisors on their website, contractors if shown as part of the organization on LinkedIn or in their online profile/website.*

- *All consultants and contractors must be **based in Canada or in one of the target market(s)**. Flag any that are outside of Canada or not in the target market, the justification must be strong.*
- Discuss the details of **each** activity. Get the client to describe exactly what this activity is about. *A detailed description of each section and a breakdown of costs for each expense is required.*
- Discuss the outcomes of **each** activity. Ensure that the outcomes are as SMART (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Realistic, and Timely) as possible.
- Is there a part of the project where one activity is more important than others?
- In the end confirm the total project amount and the grant amount (50%) so the client understands what is being applied for.
 - Discuss the differences between grant and contribution agreement.

IMPORTANT:

The program has been increasingly sensitive about the following terms used for activities, so make sure that the client is aware of the following and it is not included in their budget:

- '**Monthly Retainer Fees**' should be project based fees. It's best to avoid using the word '**Monthly**' entirely.
- '**Blogs**' or '**Content Creation**' are seen as operational and used to be eligible, no longer.
 - '**Content Creation**' can also refer to graphic content for ads, which is *eligible*. Invoices should list what the work was done to avoid confusion.
- '**Digital Ads**' are no longer eligible.
- '**Cold Calling**' is hit and miss with the program, and should be written as 'Lead Generation' to be safe. Not to hire a sales rep, more to generate interest and to help applicant book an initial call with their sales team.
- '**Consultants**' - activities routed to Category G must be strictly linked to export market research, identification of key contacts, facilitation of B2B meetings and matchmaking, feasibility studies. Any activities outside of this WILL NOT be accepted. Engaging a consultant to meet and conduct presentations with local contacts is also not accepted.
- '**Advisory**' - for legal, accounting, sales, business, belongs in Category F
- '**Website Creation**' is an ineligible expense, so don't include words like website upgrades or modification. Rather, things like 'Landing Page' creation to drive traffic to specific sections of the website is fine.
- The term '**Contactor**' should be avoided and replaced by 'Consultant'.
- '**Copywriting**' is a hit and miss with the program, so it's best to use words like 'Copy for SEO' instead.
- '**Influencer**' - expenses related to influence, including fees for influencers and key opinion leaders, are ineligible

PART B: APPLICATION INTERVIEW QUESTIONS - 30 mins

This is the part of the conversation where things are generally casual, just asking them some questions about their business based on the prompts in the Readiness Assessment template and the key questions below.

Explain to the client that the questions are simple and it really helps our writers to hear their answers in their own words so that we can write an application that sounds like it's from the company's perspective.

You don't have to ask all of the questions as you may have some of these answers already.

It is important to challenge the client on their assumptions or on the lack of detail. If they can't get past us, it means they likely won't get past an adjudicator.

- Provide an elevator pitch of your company:
 - How many employees do you have
 - When was the company established
 - How has your company been performing so far
 - What is your company's growth projection
 - *Consider asking for real numbers. If they cannot provide, make a note and be sure to follow up.*
 - Has your company won any awards?
 - What kind of clients do you currently work with? Any recognizable big names?
- Describe your products/services
 - What do you sell?
 - Where do you sell your products?
 - Who do you sell too? B2B or B2C
 - How much do your products or services cost?
 - Is your product and/or service from a Canadian Origin? If yes, how so? If not, what value is added in Canada?
 - *For tech or service based companies, ask for a ratio of outsourced (non-Canadian) and local (Canadian) teams.*
 - *For manufacturers, ask how products are imported. In raw materials or with some part assemblage already complete?*
- Do you have an IP strategy for doing business abroad? **How are you protecting your assets ?**
 - Yes/No ← *should be yes, even if they don't have a solid strategy*
 - *Make a note to clients that without a strong IP strategy, an application is unlikely to be approved. We can help in the writing process to develop a sound strategy suitable for the purposes of application but it should be clear to the client that they must have full awareness of the IP risks and relevant mitigation strategies when entering a new market. If they cannot provide accurate or detailed information at the time of interview, make a note and follow up.*

Did you consult with an IP consultant? If so, who?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Please describe your IP strategy

- List the currently in-use IP protection methods. Patents, trademarks, copyrights, etc.
- Any written policies and procedures in place to protect IP assets?
- How is confidential or internal information handled with contractors, consultants, and freelancers? Will this project require any such information being passed externally?
- Has your company ever developed an approach to international IP protection?
- Do you have standard practices in place to monitor for IP infringement?
- What technical controls protect your digital IP assets?
- What are the most relevant IP protection measures for your industry? What are the most relevant for the target market?

☐ What type of IP do they have already? (trademarks, patents, certificates, etc)

☐ What kind of IP do they want or need ? Why?

Suggest to the client that some of the project budget be devoted to IP protection measures, even if it is just for basic legal advice and research of IP protocol in the target market. This is more critical if they are entering the market for the first time and/or have been in business <5 years.

- Why are you choosing this target market over any other?
 - Specific cities?
 - review EACH market separately I.e. USA West, USA East)
 - Why is this the right time to expand into this market?
 - How did you determine that this is a viable target market? Review things like:
 - Market size or trends
 - Target consumers and buying behaviour
 - Competition and market share
 - Growth in interest from this market recently
 - Is this a repeat market from a previous CanExport application? If so, how does this project build on the work completed in a prior term?
 - Push back if the activities are essentially the same.
 - Why does this target market make the most sense to expand to? In spite of any risks you may face for success there?
- What is your international growth strategy for each market?
 - Has your company been selling to other international markets?
 - What is your initial plan for success in this target market, both qualitative and quantitative?
 - What is the plan after you've successfully established sales in the target market for this project? What countries are next?

- IF you are repeating a target market from your previous application, what value is added for the current application
 - Repeat markets are not recommended unless activities or target market are different from previous application
 - First time applicants are prioritized unless your project has a clear case on how the new project builds on the previous projects.
- Even if you are not repeating a target market, you should still learn how the previous projects have helped the client enter new markets.
 - **Be sure to read through Final Reports of previous projects to familiarize yourself with the the outcomes of each application.**
 - Why are you not focusing on target markets from previous projects? (examples revenues are too high now, tariffs, etc)
 - How have the previous projects helped you access or enter new markets?
 - What have you learned from previous projects that will help you be successful in this one?
 - Are you using a similar or different strategy/approach for this project compared to the previous ones? If yes, what is your strategy?
- Can you speak to the overall project a little bit?
 - Timeline, purpose?
 - Capacity:
 - Human Resources; Who are the key partners for the project? (both Internal: executive and leadership team; AND external: vendors, consultants, advisors)
 - Financial Resources: How are you paying for the activities in this project? Usually this is retained earnings but make not of any loans as well
 - Material Resources: raw materials, machinery, equipment, and tools, inventory, infrastructure.
 - How will this project grow your business? How will its success leverage growth in new and adjacent regions?
 - What specific opportunities exist in this market that are not present in your current one?
 - Will you be hiring any new staff in Canada as a result of this project?
- What are some challenges/risks that you see in **each** market? *Note: if there are no risks per client, ask 'Then why do you need this grant?'*
- Similarly, what are your key opportunities in this market?
- Can you describe your target demographic and clientele? Provide a general profile
- Is there any major competition in the target market?
 - Get specific company names
 - What is their profile?
 - What is your competitive advantage
 - How do you normally gain information about your competition? How do you plan to do so in this project?
- Who from your team is involved in this project?
 - Names and responsibilities.

- Are they based in Canada? **For travel, they must be Canadian employees.**
- Provide LinkedIn profiles
- Have you identified any potential partners in the target market? Potential clients?
 - Please provide specific names.
 - If not, what type of partnerships/clients would you be going for?

Note that using representatives in target market to advertise or close deals is not eligible

- *Outcomes:*
 - *What do you think you'll get out of this project in terms of return on investment?*
Please quantify.
 - *Revenues*
 - *Leads generated*
 - *Brand presence*
 - *What will come out of a successful project?*
 - *Jobs created*
 - *Interest from investors*
 - *Expansion by way of buying more equipment or growing capacity*
 - *How much investment could result from this project*